

120 Making conversation

Many words and phrases are used in English to ease the flow of conversation. These techniques are often called organizing, backchanneling, or stalling.

See also:
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Hedging 119

120.1 INFORMAL ORGANIZING WORDS

A number of general words can be used to move from one topic to another in conversational English.



"Right" gets attention before saying something important.

Right, let's get started...



"OK" acknowledges that the other speaker has been heard.

... **OK**, and are you happy with your choice?



"So" indicates that a conclusion is being reached.

... **So**, I think we agree overall.

120.2 BACKCHANNELING

When listening to another speaker, it's common to use words to show you agree and are paying attention. This is known as backchanneling.



I'm thinking about doing a course.

Really?

My company has funding...

Wow!

...and I'm really tempted to apply.

OK.

I've just moved house and my commute is very long.

Uh-huh.

The problem is, I don't have much spare time.

Oh right.

The scheme is very competitive. I'll have to see what happens.

Of course.

